



theWindow

THE NEWSLETTER OF CHRIST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH, NEW HAVEN. VOLUME 1, ISSUE 1. WINTER 1999.

Welcome to the Window!



Welcome to the new CPC newsletter! We look forward to chronicling the life of our church family in the coming years. One of our primary objectives is to help our community become more united in the body of Christ. We want this particular communication forum to benefit the CPC community, and we'd like to share some of this vision with you.

Following is the Statement of Purpose for the CPC *Window*:

We are ambitious to glorify and enjoy God by helping develop and enhance a sense of community within the body of Christ at CPC, including members, potential members, and alumni. By God's grace we will generate greater involvement interpersonally, intercongregationally, and with CPC ministries, education, and events.

We aim to do this by including the following columns in each future issue:

'From the Pastor' (a message from Pastor Preston Graham);

'Perspectives' (a personal story or testimony);

'Briefings' (a report from a servant leader in the church or an update on one of our various ministries);

'The Playground' (a feature on the children of the church).

Issues will also include a calendar of events and maybe even a Christian/Reformed perspective on some hot topics of the day—all with an eye for the overarching CPC purpose, goals, and

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ministry. We want our newsletter to keep everyone up to date, help everyone feel involved, and ultimately become one of the 'ties that bind our hearts in Christian love.' If there is anything we can add to the newsletter that would help you as a reader, please feel free to speak with someone on our team.

"And a man shall be as an hiding place from the wind, and a covert from the tempest; as rivers of water in a dry place, as the shadow of a

great rock in a weary land." —Isaiah 32:2

Jonathan Edwards used this verse from Isaiah in his sermon "Safety, Fullness, and Sweet Refreshment To Be Found in Christ," for a message preached from the pulpit of the First Christian Church of Northampton, Massachusetts (around 1726–1750). Pointing out the admiration and love due Christ for all he was and is, Edwards infuses this sermon with a sense of awe, love, and duty to the One who has called us.

As the bride of Christ, the church and sacraments are an extension of "a man," the God-man, and an extension of that "shadow of a great rock in a weary land." In this dry and weary land, there is such a need to minister to each other and the rest of the world. May we become rooted and grounded as a church, as a great rock in a weary land, and may we say together with the Apostle Paul, "We ought always to thank God for you, brothers, and rightly so, because your faith is growing more and more, and the love every one of you has for each other is increasing" (2 Thessalonians 1:3).

—Rebekah, Katie, Mary, & Mihira

Y2K and the Eschaton

BY PRESTON GRAHAM

It's the end of the world as we know it ... and I feel fine....



from the Pastor

And so goes the song by the popular rock band R.E.M. about the end times. I wonder if R.E.M. was thinking about the Y2K issue. Would they still feel fine? What about you?

Have you caught Y2K madness? Are you worried or are you fine?

We have all heard about the great catastrophes expected at the turn of the millennium. Books with titles like *Time Bomb 2000* and *The Millennium Bug* or web pages like Dr. Ed Yardeni's 'Y2K Reporter' or the 'Year 2000 Information

Center' or any one of Gary North's Y2K websites and forums all tell how the now infamous computer bug will set off a chain of events that will shut down everything from electricity to food distribution or unwittingly explode bombs and send missiles flying. And if the Y2K bug doesn't get us, more and more seem to be saying that the Y2K hysteria will! A recent documentary chronicled the increased pilgrimages of various religious groups to the 'holy land' in the anticipation of the great war of Armageddon. It was noted that if the war doesn't happen, the disappointment itself will set off a series of reactions that might stir up a war between the various factions. This has created a need for a significant increase in policing, not to mention the

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Passion Found!

BY ANNA HO



Perspectives

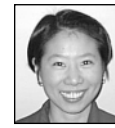
What is exciting to me about architecture is that it involves working through mysteries, just like trying to understand God and Scripture. In order to work through the mysteries of architecture, one must first develop mental and then physical representations of ideas. So, beyond making diagrams to help us understand a multi-faceted concept, architects turn the analytical results into form, or a building, as we know it. I'm sure every architect has a different approach to designing, but being able to 'see' abstract relationships and to draw clear analytical conclusions is what really excited me about architecture. Once the analysis of a given problem yields clear goals and intentions, then we are able to make those clear-cut ideas into a building, a thing that is complex, multi-layered

with information, and even poetic in its artfulness. You learn more about the mysteries of God's creation, and you make something useful and beautiful out of it. This second part of the design process is what I am learning to deal with at architecture school.

Architectural students are put into groups of ten each semester. We're given a design problem, meaning that we are to design a building of a certain type, on a given location, for a given number of people, etc. We sit with our professor, called our critic, who critiques our work regularly. Then there is a mid-term review and a final review when everyone in our class presents his or her work in public in front of the critic, a number of guest critics, and anyone else who wants to listen in. During these reviews, we are publicly chastised, praised, humiliated, advised, inspired, etc., all depending on how brutal or constructive our guest critics decide to be. Sometimes we have minor reviews called pin-ups, when we just

present to our own classmates and critic. This method of teaching may be constructive, but, as you can see, it carries a lot of performance anxieties. I know I can design, but mastery and quickness with the drawing and making of models (the most common media of architectural expression) require experience and facility. It has been tough, especially because we carry an 18-credit load instead of the average Yale load of 15 credits. I was also a professor's assistant for an architectural theory class last semester, which was wonderfully exciting.

It was hard to explain to my friends why I wanted to pursue architecture. I am passionate for God, and studying architecture has helped me to appreciate God more. Now I've found my passion!



Anna Ho is a graduate student in the Architecture program at Yale. She and her husband, Warren Ho, are members of CPC.

Meta-Narrative and the University

BY MELANIE UNRUE

"...There is in the Christian life no room for despair. Only, our hopefulness should not be founded on the sand. It should be founded, not upon a blind ignorance of the danger, but solely upon the precious promises of God. Laymen, as well as ministers, should return, in these trying days, with new earnestness, to the study of the Word of God." —J. Gresham Machen

As those saved by the blood of Christ we affirm that our lives on this earth are that of a traveler in a foreign land. This land affords a great degree of responsibility, activity, joy and sorrow but is not our ultimate destination. Rather, the treasure of our lives is being stored where neither moth nor thief can destroy in preparation for a new heavens and new earth. To despair in

this life is to forget the precious promises of Christ. Yet, upon what foundation do we make this claim?

In the midst of the university, this question is often asked by peers and one we should frequently ask ourselves. Christian, why do you believe what you believe? In a polemical world it is always easy to fall prey to extremes. Understanding the Christian faith in such a context is no exception. One is tempted to simply make brash claims about the realities of Christ with no defense at all: 'I believe what I believe just because.' On the other hand, one is also tempted to use every available means to 'humanize' and explain away the faith. At this point Christ simply becomes another equation to comprehend.

Our hope is founded neither upon ignorant innocence nor man's ability to rationalize. Rather our hope is in the King of kings and Lord of lords as He has revealed himself in Scripture. Thus how are we to confront these

trying days? By returning to the study of the Word of God as the true Israel has done throughout the ages.

In an effort to be diligent in studying the Word of God, CPC has initiated a Reformed Fellowship on Yale's campus. Led by Assistant Pastor Tom Morrison, we are presently studying the book of Ephesians. Over and over I have been struck by how Paul's understanding of the cosmos and history of mankind leads him to his knees in worship. Paul responds to life with praise and adoration because the God who extends salvation to every tribe, tongue, and nation is the same God who orchestrates and ordains all things.

I find this to be a profound contrast to my studies within the university. As I am being taught about the works of humanity throughout history and learning more and more about the arts and sciences of life, I am certainly being exposed to a vast array of knowledge. And yet this story of man and his knowledge is without a *meta-narrative*. There is no source outside of man giving a purpose or trajectory to the story.

Ultimately, such knowledge of man and inevitably his wickedness leads only to the depths of despair. It is Christ and Christ alone that is the creator, the orchestrator and the narrator of life. Praise be to God for the precious gift of studying His Word!



Melanie Unrue is a senior undergraduate student at Yale College studying Political Science. She is an associate member of CPC.



The Reformed Fellowship group on a weekend retreat to Singing Hills in New Hampshire last fall.

Y2K and the Eschaton

(continued from page 1)

various other adjustments aimed at accommodating these apocalyptic treks. What will happen if even 10% of Americans take their money out of the banks or stock market in fear of some computer malfunction that would prevent access to hard-earned cash? Maybe it is the end of the world as we know it—at least this seems to be the message some would have us consider.

Of course, apocalyptic fantasies are nothing new. But in the age of Christian culture with internet access, such visions are all the more boisterous. So then, at the turn of the millennium, R.E.M. inadvertently raises an important question: should we feel fine? Is there anything particularly significant about the year 2000 from a religious perspective?

First, let me say that I am of course no expert on computer viruses or the various economic, political or military ramifications that might be directly or indirectly related to Y2K. Needless to say, level-headed, moderate, and sober-minded analysis is always the better part of wisdom. At present, I am still in a 'wait and see' kind of posture as more information and realistic expectations begin to emerge. But as

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one who is more or less competent to speak on the issue of what the Bible teaches about the 'last days,' I think it my pastoral duty to put all this Y2K madness in perspective.

That the Bible teaches we are presently in the last days is clear. What is meant by this is that we presently live in the redemptive era that is after the Mosaic era and before the heavenly/eternal era that will be inaugurated by Christ's return. In this case, 'last' means last of a long series of eras that began with the Adamic era, followed by the Noahic era, etc. What is *not* meant then is 'last' relative to any specific calendar event, military event, political event or even some technological phenomenon. In other words, the possibility that "the end of the world as we know it" has anything to do with Y2K is as remote as the chance that it has anything to do with the fact that ladybugs congregated on my house windows in large numbers this past fall. Christ was clear about this. We cannot predict the end of the world based on any number of events or phenomena. It will come like a "thief in the night." And yet as we



The Men's Breakfast Prayer group enjoying fellowship, a meal, and discussing *Disciplines of a Godly Man*.

so often hear these days, this is exactly what some people try to do—often using very obscure teachings in the Bible to do it or perhaps pressing Biblical symbolism to a literalism that was clearly not intended by the Biblical authors. So should we be concerned that we live in the last days? Well, in short—yes! But not as you may think.

That the last days ought to concern us is clear, as in 2 Timothy 3:1: "You must understand this, that in the last days distressing times will come." Not only did Paul understand that the last days would bring certain "tribulations" as noted by Christ (Matthew 24), but that the last days should make it all the more critical that the church both guard and preach the

We are presently in the last days.

This does *not* mean 'last' relative to any specific calendar event or even some technological phenomenon.

gospel with diligence and resolve. It is true that we should live with an expectancy that life as we know it could end at any time. We should therefore cultivate a perspective that sinks roots into eternal things rather than the things of this world. We should cultivate a love for heaven and heavenly things in preparation for our eternal home, even as we pass through this age as strangers. And we should remember that, in the last days, the kingdom of God is both here and yet not fully here.

Our era is one that simultaneously enjoys the reign of God in Christ (symbolized by the millennium reign of Christ in Revelation) and

suffers the regulated reign of Satan for a time (symbolized by seven years in Revelation). The numbers 7 and 1,000 are both symbolic numbers representing a perfect and designated time to accomplish God's perfect ends. We read Revelation this way because the New Covenant

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interprets similar kinds of symbols in Daniel in a similar manner. We therefore live with a heavenly perspective in anticipation of the Lord's return. But to live with an anticipation for the "end of the world as we know it" is very different than to plan as if it will end soon. So we plan for the future both in this world and in the world to come. And how then should we feel about all this? Paul gives us the right answer.

"So we are always confident; even though we know that while we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord—for we walk by faith, not by sight. Yes, we do have confidence, and we would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord. So whether we are at home or away, we make it our aim to please him."

—2 Corinthians 5:6–9

...and I feel fine....



Rev. Preston Graham is the Pastor of CPC and is not building a bomb shelter or stocking up on fuel and gasoline for the turn of the century.

Calendar of Events

March

- 5-21 Yale Spring Break
- 12 & 13 Teacher training: Hermeneutics
- 19 Singles Meal and Movie Night – 6:30 pm, Study Center (sc)
- 27 Service Project & Men's Prayer Breakfast
- 31 Surveys & Leaders Commitment & Budgets due for next year

April

- 2 Easter Outreach Service
- 4 Easter Sunday; family dinners with students
- 8 Session meeting
- 11 Alan Phillips' shepherding group – 1:00 pm, sc
- 16-17 Servant Leader training
- 23 Yale classes end

Weekly Meetings

- MON English for International Students – 2:30 pm, sc
- TUE Women's Fellowship Group & Children's story hour (same time) – 9:45 am, sc
Reformed Fellowship meeting for undergraduates – 6:30 pm, Dwight Hall
- WED Fellowship meal followed by School of Discovery
- SUN Reformed Fellowship meetings, after service



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Editors Katie Levesque

Rebekah Prokop

Graphic Designer Mihira Jayasekera

Website Designer Mary Smith



Anna and Ellen bob for apples during the Harvest Party in October.



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135 Whitney Avenue, New Haven, CT 06510